

product that was a three-foot by four-foot mobile kiosk that included an energy-efficient, consumer-grade washing machine, a dryer, and an extra-long extension cord. The kiosk used Western detergents and was supplied daily with fresh clean water delivered by VLS.

Since then, the Village Laundry Service has grown substantially, with fourteen locations operational in Bangalore, Mysore, and Mumbai. As CEO Akshay Mehra shared with me, “We have serviced 116,000 kgs. in 2010 (vs. 30,600 kg. in 2009). And almost 60 percent of the business is coming from repeat customers. We have serviced more than 10,000 customers in the past year alone across all the outlets.”⁵

A LEAN STARTUP IN GOVERNMENT?

On July 21, 2010, President Obama signed the Dodd–Frank Wall Street Reform and Consumer Protection Act into law. One of its landmark provisions created a new federal agency, the Consumer Federal Protection Bureau (CFPB). This agency is tasked with protecting American citizens from predatory lending by financial services companies such as credit card companies, student lenders, and payday loan offices. The plan calls for it to accomplish this by setting up a call center where trained case workers will field calls directly from the public.

Left to its own devices, a new government agency would probably hire a large staff with a large budget to develop a plan that is expensive and time-consuming. However, the CFPB is considering doing things differently. Despite its \$500 million budget and high-profile origins, the CFPB is really a startup.

President Obama tasked his chief technology officer, Aneesh Chopra, with collecting ideas for how to set up the new startup agency, and that is how I came to be involved. On one of Chopra's visits to Silicon Valley, he invited a number of entrepreneurs to make suggestions for ways to cultivate a startup mentality in the new agency. In particular, his focus was on leveraging technology